



a job at Intel would bring stability to his career and a chance to build something new.

Amidst all the chaos of building a career, there was one aspect of life that Taher had not yet given much thought to—marriage. With his life revolving around academics, work, and survival, relationships had never been a priority.

“Back in Calcutta, all the girls I had taught called me ‘Sir.’ There was never any romantic angle because they saw me as a teacher, someone to be respected, not pursued. And by the time I was ready to think about marriage, most of them were already married!” he laughs.

With each passing day, his mother, like a typical Indian mom, was worried that Taher would never settle down. So, when he visited India after securing his job at Intel, she decided to take matters into her own hands.

“I had one condition—I wanted to marry a professional woman. In the US, life as a homemaker can be isolating, and I did not want my wife to feel that way. She had to have a career of her own,” he says.

His cousin, who lived in Nagpur, introduced him to Farida, a doctor from the city, who would become his life partner. They got married in 1992. “I couldn’t become a doctor, but we do have a doctor’s degree in our house,” he quips!

They have now been married for 32 years and have a daughter who works as a nurse. “She gave me the freedom to chase my ambitions, and I gave her the same. She became the assistant chief of a hospital, and I became a CEO. We both grew together,” he reflects.

Despite all his achievements, the relationships he has built—both



With Louisiana parents—being pampered by mom

personal and professional—are what he holds closest to his heart.

Tutor turned trailblazer

At Intel, Taher started as an engineer working on microprocessors. He was part of the team that designed the Pentium processors—technology that would eventually power millions of computers worldwide.

“I worked on four versions—Pentium I, II, III, and Itanium. The first time, it was incredibly challenging. But after the fourth version, it became repetitive,” he shares. He had reached a point where he wanted more. More challenges, more learning, and more opportunities to innovate.

In the 1990s, Intel was at its peak and held nearly 90% of the microprocessor market, looking for ways to expand beyond computing. They saw an opportunity in supplying silicon to networking and communication—a space that companies like Cisco were rapidly dominating. Taher saw this as his next challenge. “I had spent years working on processors, and the move from computing to communications was something new,” he says.

However, fate had something else planned. Despite investing

billions into the communication sector, Intel failed to win market share from TI, PMC-Sierra, Broadcom, and Conexant. “We spent billions acquiring companies, but the experiment failed. With that, my career also took a hit,” he admits.

But failure had never stopped him before. And it was not about to stop him now.

During this time, Taher and his friends at Intel identified a gap in the semiconductor industry. Outsourcing

chip development was an expensive and inefficient process, dominated by large corporations charging exorbitant prices. “We realised that semiconductor design was overpriced. Instead, we could design and get semiconductor chips manufactured at much lower prices and still be profitable,” he explains.

Seeing an opportunity to disrupt the industry, he and his colleagues took a leap of faith. In 2003, Taher joined Open-Silicon, a company focused on making chip development more accessible and affordable. The Open-Silicon team pitched their idea to investors and secured \$45 million in funding. “At the time, this was a massive amount—equivalent to around \$300 million today,” he says.

Within a few years, Open-Silicon became a success story, challenging industry giants and lowering the barriers for startups to develop their own chips. In 2007, the company was bought over by a private equity firm for \$200 million. Many of the original founders exited over time and moved on, but Taher stayed. “By then, money was no longer my motivation. I wanted to build something bigger,” he says. He continued as CEO, leading the company till it was sold again in 2018.